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By Philip Loft

Israel/US-Iran conflict 2026: Reopening the Strait of Hormuz

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Summary

On 28 February 2026, Israel and the United States began a series of strikes against Iran. They said they aimed to induce regime change in the country and target its nuclear and ballistic missile programme. Iran's supreme leader, Ali Khamenei, was killed in the strikes. Iran has appointed his son as successor and launched a series of counter-strikes against Israel, US military bases in the region, and military and civilian locations in Arab states. One Iranian counter action was closing the Strait of Hormuz, a major global trade route for goods, including fuel and gas.

While a conditional ceasefire is in place (extended until talks are concluded), shipping levels through the strait remain very low. The US has since announced a counter-blockade on ships seeking to use Iranian ports. There are also defensive UK and other initiatives under discussion to reopen the strait to vessels. The Library's Iran in 2026 collection provides more on the 2026 conflict, Iran and US-Iran talks.

The Strait of Hormuz and global shipping

The Strait of Hormuz is a major trade route. Around 20% of global petroleum and 20% of liquified natural gas (LNG) traverses the strait each year. Pre-conflict, around 3,000 vessels used the strait each month. World Trade Organization data suggests a 95% reduction in ships carrying crude oil to and from Persian Gulf ports and a 99% reduction in ships with LNG since the conflict began. This has pushed up global prices (benefiting both Russia and, in the short term, Iran). The United Arab Emirate (UAE)'s state-owned oil company estimates full flows through Hormuz will not resume until 2027, even if a deal is reached quickly.

While much of the strait and the Persian Gulf lie in international waters, its narrowest part is within Iranian and Omani territorial waters. The ship route consists of two-mile-wide navigable channels.

What restrictions has Iran imposed?

Following the US/Israeli strikes, Iran said it would block ships, aside from those of "non hostile" states, from using the strait. The Iranian Government is also reportedly imposing tolls on ships transitioning the strait. In May it proposed Iranian control of wider parts of the strait, a new body to manage it, and continued to reportedly develop a "tiered system" of control to allow ships of specific countries to use the strait (sometimes for a fee). It has

suggested talks with Oman on the management on the strait and tolls, drawing US criticism.

Iran has said that its control of the strait must continue after the conflict (this was not the case before February), though President Trump has said that any agreement must allow the unrestricted movement of shipping. He said Oman, which has historically played a mediatory role between Iran and the US, would be "blow[n] [...] up" if they did not "behave like everybody else".

While Iranian naval strength is greatly diminished, threats from drones, mines and small ships, as well as insurance costs, mean shipping companies remain hesitant to use the route.

US statements and counter-blockade

Military measures and counter-blockade

In response to the Iranian statements, in March President Trump requested support from NATO allies, China, Japan and South Korea to secure access through the strait. However, they declined to do so during hostilities. The President later said that support from other states was not required.

On 13 April, the US launched a counter-blockade of the strait, targeting all ships seeking to reach Iranian ports. Iran has threatened military action if the US blockade does not end. The US says it has redirected 127 commercial ships.

On 3 May, the president announced the US would launch "project freedom" to escort ships through the strait as a "humanitarian gesture". Only limited action was taken by the time the president paused the plan on 5 May, citing a request from Pakistan to allow the ceasefire talks to continue.

Sanctions and talks

In an attempt to lower global oil prices, in March the US temporarily removed sanctions on some Russian oil and Iranian oil already in transit. Both exemptions have since expired. The 32 members of the International Energy Agency, including the UK, have also released 400 million barrels of oil.

The reopening of the strait is a major issue in the Pakistan-mediated talks. The US Secretary of State has said any Iranian tolling system in the strait "would make a diplomatic deal unfeasible". On 12 April, President Trump had said that under the conditional ceasefire, "Iran promised to open the strait of Hormuz, and they knowingly failed to do so". The president has previously threated extensive attacks on Iranian infrastructure if shipping does not resume through the strait. He said that a planned US attack on Iran on 19 May was paused because of Arab Gulf opposition.

Diplomatic initiatives

UK and France have hosted two international conferences

The UK and France have hosted two conferences on reopening Hormuz, with a focus on exploring potential sanctions, diplomatic initiatives and insurance provision for ships. They have signed a statement, alongside 36 other countries, expressing their readiness to contribute to efforts to ensure safe passage and condemning attacks on commercial shipping. On 17 April, France and the UK said they would establish an international defensive mission for the strait, once a sustainable ceasefire has been agreed.

The two held a meeting on 11 May to discuss their commitments. The UK said it will commit autonomous mine hunting equipment, counter-drone systems, Typhoon jets, HMS Dragon and potentially RFA Lyme Bay to the defensive mission, once it is operational. HMS Dragon has been sent to the region, as has France's Charles de Gaulle aircraft carrier group. Iran has criticised the planned deployments, saying it will deliver "a decisive and immediate response" if they are sent to the strait.

Draft UN Security Council in April vetoed by China and Russia

On 7 April, China and Russia vetoed a draft resolution on the strait of Hormuz. The Bahraini-drafted resolution called for an end to Iranian attacks and for states to "coordinate efforts" defensively for shipping access, including escorts for ships. However, China has called on freedom of navigation in the strait to be guaranteed as the "shared call of the international community". The UK backed the resolution, as did the United States.

Further resolutions are being drafted, but with no votes arranged

In May, the US said it was drafting a new, "narrower" resolution, with input from some Arab Gulf states. France has also said it is preparing a resolution to establish an international mission to restore freedom of movement in the strait. Neither have been scheduled for a vote.

1 Shipping and the Strait of Hormuz

The Strait of Hormuz runs between the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman and carries a substantial proportion of the global trade, including petroleum, natural gas trade and fertilizer. At its narrowest (29 nautical miles), it is solely within Iranian and Omani waters, and the route for ships is only two miles wide. It has long been a site of geopolitical tension.[1]

During the 2026 conflict, Iran has announced a blockade. The US has since announced a counter-blockade on ships seeking to enter Iranian ports as part of negotiations to end the conflict and attempts to reopen the strait to trade.

1.1 What is the significance of the strait?

As shown in the following two maps, the Strait of Hormuz is a significant global trading route for goods including petroleum and natural gas.

20% of global petroleum flows through the strait

Annually, an estimated 20% of global petroleum and 27% of global traded oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz. It is particularly important to Asian markets, with China and India combined receiving 44% of the crude oil exports from the route in 2025. As well as exports of oil products, many other global goods like aluminium and fertilisers traverse the strait.

The reliance of oil-producing Gulf states on the route differs, but about 93% of Qatar's and 96% of the UAE's liquid natural gas (LNG) exports transit the route. These constitute around 19% of global LNG trade. Most Iranian trade is also via the strait, and is now hindered by the current conflict. Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) have an alternative export route, via the Red Sea.[2]

Houthi attacks on Red Sea shipping did not resume in 2026

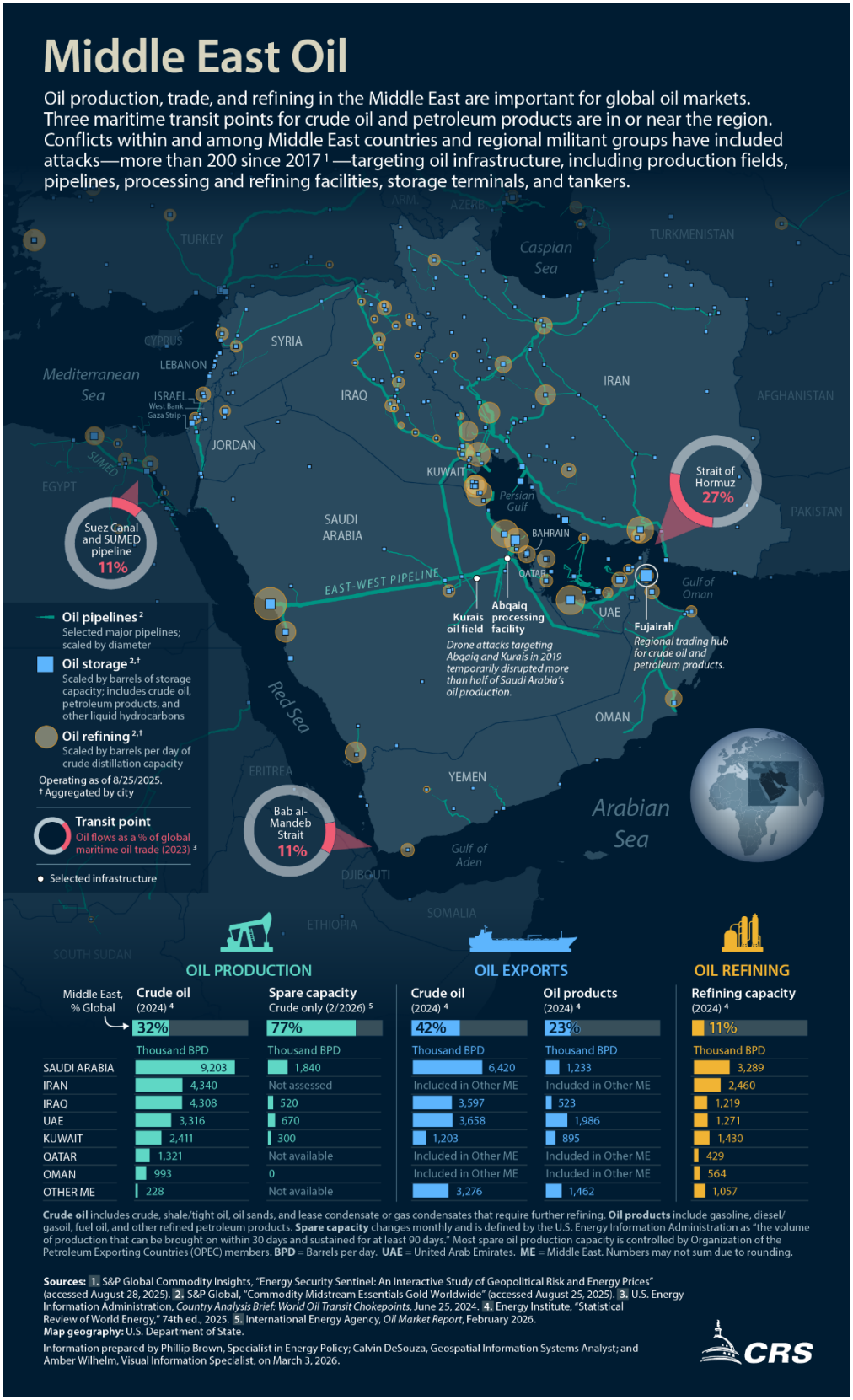
This also makes the Bab al-Mandeb Strait, at the tip of the Red Sea, a substantial bottleneck in global trade.[3] From 2023 to 2025, the Iran-backed Houthis in Yemen curtailed access to the Bab al-Mandeb Strait, leading to US and UK military intervention. While the attacks ended with the October 2025 agreement between Israel and Hamas, shipping levels in the Red Sea remain 60% lower than 2023 and in June 2026 the Houthis said the route would be closed to Israeli ships.[4]

1 For a summary of tensions in the 1980s, see Congressional Research Service, Iran conflict and the Strait of Hormuz: impacts on oil, gas, and other commodities, March 2026

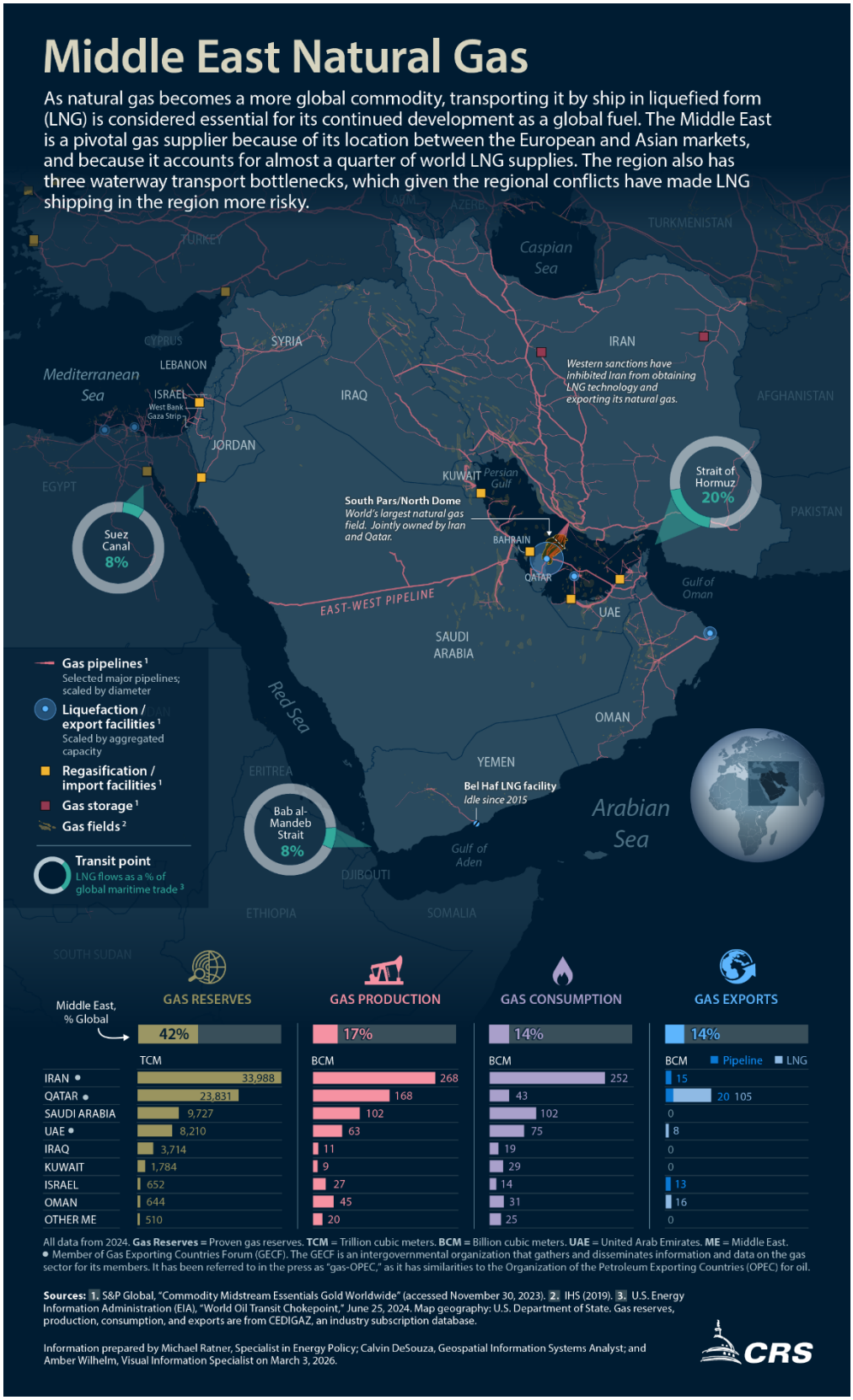
2 International Energy Authority, Strait of Hormuz: Factsheet, 2026; Foreign Affairs, For Iran, Hormuz is more a weakness than a weapon, 15 April 2026

3 Bloomberg, Saudi pipeline to bypass Hormuz hits 7 million barrel goal, 28 March 2026

4 Reuters, Western powers were unable to secure shipping in the Red Sea, 25 March 2026; Asharq Al-Aswat, Houthis attack Israel, declare ban on Israeli shipping in Red Sea, 8 June 2026



Source: US Congressional Research Service, Middle East oil, 3 March 2026. No copyright.



Source: US Congressional Research Service, Middle East natural gas, 3 March 2026. No copyright.

1.2 Iranian blockade and tolls

Iran did not control the strait before the conflict began

Iran has called for control of the Strait post-conflict

In his first statement as Iran's Supreme Leader on 12 March, Mojtaba Khamenei said that the "lever of blocking the Strait of Hormuz must continue to be used".[5] He has subsequently said that Iran will "secure the Persian Gulf" under "new legal rules and new management".[6]

The country's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi has said that Iran must continue to control the strait after the conflict. Before the conflict, Iran did not have sole control of the strait: much the Gulf lies in international waters and the rest was controlled by Iran in conjunction with Oman.[7]

Refusal to reopen the strait during ceasefire

There is dispute within Iran on reopening the strait during the ceasefire and conditions of access (see below). On 17 April the Iranian Foreign Minister had said that, following the Lebanon ceasefire agreement (on which talks continue), all commercial vessels would be allowed through the strait for the duration of the ceasefire.[8] However, Iran's national security council later said that so long as the US blockade continues (see below), Iran's will also.[9]

Some countries have come to an agreement with Iran to allow some ships to pass

Iran has allowed a small number of vessels from "non hostile" states to pass through during the conflict, including from China, France, Pakistan, India and Iraq. Any ships deemed to be affiliated with the US or Israel are blocked. No UK ships have been confirmed to have crossed through the strait.[10]

The US initially said it was content for trade on these ships to continue in an attempt to keep down global oil and gas prices.[11]

New Iranian mechanism on the strait

Since the conflict began, the Iranian government has announced several steps to increase its control over shipping traversing the strait. These have included:[12]

5 Reuters, Iran's new supreme leader vows to keep Hormuz shut, 12 March 2026; UN, Iran ceasefire raises hopes for reopening key Strait of Hormuz, 8 April 2026
6 BBC Monitoring, Iran supreme leader says war opened "new chapter", 30 April 2026
7 BBC Monitoring, Iran says its control over Strait of Hormuz will continue after war, 25 March 2026
8 Seyed Abbas Araghchi on Twitter/X, "In line with the ceasefire in Lebanon", 17 April 2026
9 Tasmin News Agency, SNSC: Iran to maintain control over Hormuz Strait, 19 April 2026
10 Financial Times, Iran says "non-hostile" ships can transit Strait of Hormuz, 24 March 2026; BBC News, Asian nations already have deals with Iran, 7 April 2026; Reuters, Japanese, French and Omani vessels cross the strait, 3 April 2026
11 CNBC, US is allowing Iranian oil tankers through Strait of Hormuz, says Bessent, 16 March 2026
12 The below from Crisis Group, The state of the strait, 29 May 2026

- A new management body (the "Persian Gulf Strait Authority") to govern the strait.[13]
- A new route through the strait via Iran's territorial waters. Before the conflict, ship traffic was directed under the Traffic Separation Scheme, agreed by Iran and Oman, and since adopted by the UN's International Maritime Organisation.
- Claiming greater control over some maritime areas in the region.[14]
- Reportedly beginning a tiered system of passage, though the degree of implementation is unclear. Reuters news agency suggests the tiers are between Iran's closest diplomatic partners (Russia, China), countries to which it is otherwise close (India, Pakistan) and states to whom it has come to an agreement for them to use the strait for individual ships.[15]
- Launching a toll and insurance system. The full nature of agreements that allow individual ships to traverse the strait is unclear.[16] In March, Lloyd's List Intelligence had reported Iran was beginning a "toll booth" system, which requires ship operators to submit to an Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) vetting scheme unless their government has a diplomatic agreement with Iran to use the route. Some ships had reportedly paid the toll in Chinese yuan (through avoiding the US dollar, this helps Iran to evade US sanctions and facilitates direct Iran-China trade).[17]

The US has subsequently sanctioned Iran's strait authority, saying "anyone cooperating with the so-called strait authority may be providing support to and receiving services from the IRGC". The US has previously warned that paying tolls to Iran would potentially breach US sanctions against Iran.[18]

As of late May, draft legislation was reportedly under consideration by the Iranian parliament to formalise Iran's control measures.[19]

International law, tolls and freedom of navigation

In international law, the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) sets out the main freedoms of navigation in different contexts (PDF).

13 BBC Monitoring, Iran launches new Strait of Hormuz managing body, 18 May 2026
14 Al Jazeera, Map of dominance: Why Iran can't afford to give up Hormuz control, 5 May 2026
15 Reuters, Iran is consolidating control of Hormuz [...], 30 May 2026
16 Reuters, Opaque oil deals around Hormuz test the petrodollar, 18 May 2026
17 Lloyd's List, Tehran's 'toll booth' system is now controlling Hormuz traffic, 25 March 2026 and Shipping seeks clarity over Tehran toll booth, 8 April 2026
18 US Treasury Department, Economic fury targets Iranian maritime extortion, 27 May 2026
19 BBC Monitoring, Iran parliament moves to formalise Hormuz Strait controls, 30 May 2026

Neither the US nor Iran are parties to UNCLOS, while Oman is (Oman, together with Iran, has its coastline on the strait). However, it has been the longstanding position of the US that the law of the sea is customary international law.

Freedoms of navigation take different forms depending on the seas, or maritime areas, a ship intends to pass through. Full freedom of navigation generally applies on the "high seas", the area of seas outside of a state's territorial waters, under Articles 86-7 of UNCLOS. The Strait of Hormuz is an area of sea that traverses the sovereign waters of both Iran and Oman. In these circumstances specific rules of international law apply.

UNCLOS Part III sets out the rules relating to straits used for international navigation, and Article 38 provides the right of "transit passage". This means that all ships and aircraft have the right to transit through a strait unimpeded. This freedom of navigation through a strait applies for the purpose of a continuous and expeditious transit of a strait between one part of the high seas (or exclusive economic zone)[20] and another.

Article 39 of UNCLOS applies some legal duties on ships and aircraft passing through a strait, including requirements that they shall:

- Proceed without delay through or over the strait.
- Refrain from any threat or use of force against the sovereignty, territorial integrity, or political independence of the bordering states (in this case, Iran and Oman).
- Refrain from any activities other than those related to their "normal modes of continuous and expeditious transit," unless necessitated by force majeure or distress.
- Comply with accepted international regulations for safety at sea (such as collision avoidance) and the prevention of pollution.

Iran and Oman had agreed official shipping lanes for navigating the strait, which were adopted by the International Maritime Organization in 1968.

Passage through a strait must also be 'innocent' (see Articles 17-26 and 45 UNCLOS), meaning that passage is permitted "so long as it is not prejudicial to the peace, good order, or security" of the coastal state. Article 19 provides a list of activities that are considered to fit this threshold, including issues such as the threat of force against the coastal state, weapons use, wilful and serious pollution, fishing, and other similar examples.

[20] An exclusive economic zone (EEZ) refers to a maritime area extending up to 200 nautical miles from a coastal state's baseline, the legally recognised line along the country's coast

Under UNCLOS, the coastal states bordering a strait are obliged under Article 44 of UNCLOS not to hamper passage, to publicise any danger to navigation, and the suspension of transit passage is prohibited. This is unlike the right of states (under Article 25(3), UNCLOS) to temporarily suspend passage through their specified areas of its territorial sea in limited circumstances, including essential security protections or weapons exercises.

Article 26 of UNCLOS also provides that states are prohibited from charging ships any fees simply for passing through a state's territorial sea (unless specific services are offered, without discrimination).

Blockades are primarily governed by customary international law.[21] The International Red Cross summarises conditions for a mandatory blockade:

> To be mandatory, that is, for third States to be obliged to respect it, the blockade must be effective. This means that it must be maintained by a force sufficient to prevent all access to the enemy coast. The belligerent must declare the existence of the blockade. The belligerent must also specify [...] the starting date, geographical limits of the blockaded territory and time allowed to neutral vessels to leave. This declaration must be notified to all neutral Powers and to the local authorities.[22]

Further reading

Further reading on the legal aspects of the US and Iranian blockades can be found in section 1.6.

Iran-Oman talks

The Iranian and Omani governments are in talks on regularising control over the strait.[23] Oman's state-news agency said that the talks discussed "possible options" for the strait and the New York Times suggests this may have included charging fees to access the strait.[24]

President Trump has said Oman, which plays a mediatory role in US-Iran relations, will be "blow[n] up" if it does "not behave like everybody else".[25] The US Treasury Secretary has said any "willing partners" to Iran would be "penalised" for establishing a toll system.[26]

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21 Philip Drew, The law of maritime blockade, chapter 5. See also the San Remo Manual and UN Report of the Secretary-General's Panel of Inquiry on the 31 May 2010 Gaza Flotilla Incident, Appendix 1, paras 16-42

22 International Committee of the Red Cross, Casebook: Blockade

23 BBC Monitoring, Iran says discussing Hormuz shipping mechanism with Oman, 17 May 2026

24 Al-Arabiya, Oman, Iran hold talks on Strait of Hormuz: Omani state news agency, 5 April 2026; New York Times, Iran and Oman in talks over Strait of Hormuz [...], 21 May 2026

25 Al Monitor, Trump threatens to 'blow up' Oman as US-Iran talks stall, 27 May 2026

26 Reuters, US warns Oman not to engage in facilitating tolls for Strait of Hormuz, 28 May 2026

Shipping numbers remain very low

Almost no ships carrying LNG have passed through the strait since the conflict began

While multiple Iranian naval ships have been destroyed by the US, limiting their ability to restrict access, threats from mines, drones, missiles and small boats through the corridor have contributed to continued hesitancy to use the route. On 22 April Iran claimed to have captured two cargo ships.[27]

The number of trackable ships traversing the strait with goods from or for Persian Gulf ports has fallen substantially, according to data collected by the World Trade Organization (WTO). From 28 February to 1 June, it estimates the number of ships carrying crude oil has dropped by 95%, LNG ships by 99% and ships with fertilizer by 87%.[28]

1.3 US and global response: Coalitions, sanctions, counter blockade and oil reserves release

Requests for international support to secure Hormuz

Multiple states have committed to support steps to reopen the strait after the end of hostilities and there is ongoing debate at the UN Security Council on a potential resolution. See below, sections 1.4 and 1.5.

President Trump has criticised NATO for not supporting the strait's reopening

On 20 March the US President criticised other NATO states for saying they would not participate in military action to secure the strait, "now that fight is militarily won".[29] The German Defence Minister said "this is not our war", and France and the EU High Representative for Foreign Affairs (among others) have made similar statements.[30] President Trump has also said that the US "do[es] not need the help of anyone" to secure the region,[31] while also requesting Chinese and NATO action to help secure the strait.[32] The US has since announced it has begun demining operations in the strait.[33]

On 27 March, Secretary of State Marco Rubio said that the US expected other states to lead on the securing of Hormuz after the conflict, though the country is "happy to be a part of it".[34]

27 BBC News, Iran says it has seized two ships in Strait of Hormuz, 22 April 2026
28 WTO, Strait of Hormuz trade tracker, updated 1 June 2026
29 Truth Social Donald Trump, "Without the USA, NATO is a paper tiger!", 20 March 2026
30 FT, Donald Trump warns Nato faces 'very bad future' if allies fail to help US in Iran, 15 March 2026; Reuters, 'Not our war': Europe says no to Trump, 19 March 2026
31 Truth Social Donald Trump, "The US has been informed by most of our NATO 'allies'", 17 March 2026
32 Truth Social Donald Trump, "Many countries, especially those who are affected", 14 March 2026
33 US Centcom, US forces start mine clearance mission, 11 April 2026
34 US State Department, Secretary of State Marco Rubio remarks to press, 27 March 2026

These follow an earlier statement by President Trump on 3 March that the US navy would, "if necessary [...] begin escorting tankers through the strait [...], as soon as possible". No escort plan was announced until May (see below).[35]

US announcement it would blockade Iranian ports

President Trump has threatened to attack Iran's energy sites and bridges

On 21 March and 6 April, President Trump threatened to "obliterate" Iran's power plants if Iran did not immediately open the strait. He said that 7 April would be "power plant day, and bridge day", with the US attacking these sites across Iran. However, with the announcement of Pakistan-media talks (see the separate Library briefing), these attacks did not take place.[36]

Following the announcement of the mediated talks, the US announced that from 13 April it would begin a blockade of ships seeking to use Iranian ports in the Persian Gulf. It will not target ships using other ports.[37] President Trump said "we're not going to let Iran make money on selling oil to people that they like".[38] The Treasury Secretary, Scott Bessnnet, said one purpose is to shut down Iranian oil production, as its storage facilities will be full.[39]

The President also said that the US navy would "seek and interdict every vessel in international waters that has paid a toll to Iran".[40]

Iran and the US maintain their respective blockades

To 6 June, the US has directly intercepted some vessels engaged in sanctioned oil trade with Iran (in the Indian Ocean) and redirected 127 commercial ships away from the strait.[41] President Trump has said that the US will not end the blockade "until such time as our transaction [talks and agreement] with Iran is 100% complete".[42]

On 13 April, UK Prime Minister Sir Keir Starmer said that the UK will not be "getting involved in the proposal to blockade the strait".[43] China has described the US action as "dangerous and irresponsible" and called on both Iran and the US to "restore normal navigation in the strait at an early date".[44]

Saudi Arabia has reportedly expressed concern to the US administration that its action may encourage the Iran-backed Houthis to attack and disrupt Red Sea shipping routes, as was the case from 2023 to 2025.[45]

35 Truth Social Donald Trump, "Effective immediately, I have ordered [...]", 3 March 2026
36 BBC News, Trump issues expletive-laden threat to Iran over Hormuz Strait blockage, 6 April 2026
37 Centom, US to blockade ships entering or exiting Iranian ports, 12 April 2026
38 Fox News, Trump details sweeping 'all or nothing' blockade, 12 April 2026
39 Treasury Secretary on Twitter/X, "As @POTUS has made clear", 21 April 2026
40 Donald Trump on Truth Social, "So, there you have it, the meeting went well", 12 April 2026
41 Centcom, US forces disable vessel attempting to enter Iranian port, 19 April 2026; Centcom on Twitter/X, "A U.S. Sailor stands watch [...]", 4 June 2026
42 Donald Trump on Truth Social, "The Strait of Hormuz is completely open", 17 April 2026
43 HC Deb, 13 April 2026, c559
44 South China Morning Post, China hits out at [...] US blockade, 14 April 2026
45 Wall Street Journal, Saudi Arabia is pressing US to drop its naval blockade, 13 April 2026

Iran has threatened action in other seas if the blockade continues

Iran has said that it would threaten trade in the Persian Gulf, Red Sea and Gulf of Oman if the US "create[s] insecurity for Iran's commercial vessels", describing the US action as a "prelude to a violation of the ceasefire".[46]

Particularly due to wide US sanctions, Iran's economy has been struggling for several years, with high inflation. In May, Iran's central bank said the inflation rate had risen to 77%. Like its Gulf neighbours, Iran is dependent on the strait for most of its trade, including staples such as rice, cooking oil and sugar, and for income from its trade in sanctioned oil to China.[47]

Launch and pause of "project freedom"

On 3 May, President Trump announced that the US would launch "project freedom", under which the US would help ships currently stranded in the strait to exit it.[48] The US navy deployed around 100 land and sea-based aircraft, drones and missile destroyers in a "defensive mission".[49]

The operation was paused in response to Pakistan and Saudi requests for more time for talks

In response to the announcement, the Iranian government said that "any foreign armed force [...] [that] approach[es] or enter[s] the Strait of Hormuz, will be targeted and attacked".[50] The US navy confirmed that some Iranian missiles targeted the US navy and commercial ships around the strait as the operation began, and under which two US merchant ships were able to leave the strait.[51]

The operation was paused on 5 May. President Trump said he did so following a request from Pakistan and other countries who are seeking to mediate an end to the conflict. The president said it would be a "short" pause.[52] Saudi Arabia was among the states to request a pause and also to put restrictions on the US military's use of their bases and airspace for the operation.[53]

46 Al Jazeera, Iran warns US naval blockade threatens ceasefire, 15 April 2026
47 BBC Monitoring, How realistic is Iran's downplaying of US naval blockade?, 16 April 2026; ABC, Iran's inflation hits World War II levels, deepening economic pain, 2 June 2026
48 Truth Social Donald Trump, "Countries from all over the world [...]", 3 May 2026
49 US Centcom, US military supports launch of operation project freedom, 3 May 2026
50 Al Jazeera, Iran warns US to stay out of Hormuz, 4 May 2026
51 US Centcom. Centcom commander conducts a media conference call, 4 May 2026
52 Truth Social Donald Trump, "Based on the request of Pakistan [...]", 5 May 2026
53 Shehbaz Sharif on Twitter/X, "I am grateful to President Donald Trump [...]", 6 May 2026; Wall Street Journal, Gulf states lift restrictions that blocked "project freedom" [...], 7 May 2026

Temporary lifting of US sanctions on Russian and Iranian oil

Russia has benefited financially from rising oil prices

Conflict in the strait has increased global oil and gas prices, as well as demand for sanctioned Russian oil and gas.[54] Russia has a reported a "significant increase" in demand since the start of the conflict.[55]

On 6 March the US issued a temporary sanctions waiver for India to purchase sanctioned Russian oil stranded at sea. This was expanded on 13 March to other countries and to include Russian oil already in transit. The waiver was then renewed to 16 May, after which it expired.[56]

On 20 March, the US also issued a "short-term authorization permitting the sale of Iranian oil currently stranded at sea". The US Treasury Secretary said that "sanctioned Iranian oil is being hoarded by China" and "we will be using the Iranian barrels against Tehran to keep the price down". The change did not affect new production or purchases.[57] The measure was not extended, and the US has subsequently announced further sanctions on Iran's oil fleet.[58]

International oil reserves released

On 11 March the 32 members of the International Energy Agency (IEA) agreed to make 400 million barrels of oil from their emergency reserves available to the market. This was the sixth coordinated stock release by the IEA since it was established in 1974, having been created in response to the 1973 Arab oil embargo.[59]

IEA members hold emergency stockpiles of around 1.2 billion barrels. The industry is also required to reserve 600 million barrels.[60]

The UK contributed 13.5 million barrels to the release. For more information on the UK action, see the Department for Energy Security and Net Zero's UK joins IEA members in coordinated oil stock release, 11 March 2026.

54 Atlantic Council, How the broadening Middle East conflict could strengthen Russia [...], 3 March 2026

55 Al Jazeera, Moscow sees significant rise in demand for Russian oil, gas amid Iran war, 6 March 2026

56 BBC News, US eases sanctions on Russian oil sales to India during Iran conflict, 6 March 2026; DW, US temporarily allows sale of Russian oil stranded at sea, 13 March 2026; US Treasury Department, Russia-related general license, 19 March 2026 and Russia-related general license, 17 April 2026

57 Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent on Twitter/X, "Iran is the head of the snake for global terrorism", 20 March 2026; US Treasury Department, Issuance of Iran-related general license, 20 March 2026

58 US Treasury Department, Economic fury targets illicit oil smuggling network, 15 April 2026 and Economic fury targets illicit oil revenue, 28 May 2026

59 IEA, IEA member countries to carry out largest ever oil stock release, 11 March 2026

60 IEA, IEA member countries to carry out largest ever oil stock release, 11 March 2026

1.4 UK diplomatic action on the Strait of Hormuz

Diplomatic statements

The UK Government opposes the tolls and permissions system that Iran has put in place

Together with 37 other countries, the UK has "express[ed] [its] readiness to contribute to appropriate efforts to ensure safe passage through the Strait". The UAE and Bahrain are among those to back the statement. They collectively "condemn[ed] in the strongest terms recent attacks by Iran on unarmed commercial vessels in the Gulf" and civilian sites elsewhere.[61]

The UK Government has called for the "full and unconditional" reopening of the strait and said there is "no place for tolls or permissions".[62] It has said the creation of new structures by Iran to manage the strait (see above, section 1.2), are "a breach of international law".[63]

UK-hosted conferences on reopening Hormuz

The Prime Minister has said that the UK is working on a "viable, collective plan" with European partners to reopen the strait as soon as possible.[64] The government has said, however, "we will not get drawn into a wider war".[65]

The UK is exploring mechanisms like sanctions and insurance

The Foreign Secretary, Yvette Cooper, hosted a virtual conference on the strait on 2 April, in which over 40 countries participated. The participants committed to further discussions to continue on four themes:

1. Increase international diplomatic pressure, including through the UN, against Iranian control and any imposition of tolls
2. Explore coordinated measures, including sanctions, if the strait does not reopen
3. Working to release ships and sailors currently stranded in the strait
4. Support greater market confidence, such as improved information sharing for shipping companies and operators.[66]

[61] Prime Minister's Office, Joint statement from the leaders of the UK [...], 19 March 2026
[62] FCDO, We must step up efforts together to safeguard international waterways [...], 27 April 2026
[63] HC Deb, 21 May 2026, c759
[64] Prime Minister's Office, PM remarks, 16 March 2026
[65] HC Deb, 16 March 2026, c636
[66] FCDO, Chair's statement on the meeting on the Strait of Hormuz, 2 April 2026

The UK and France will lead a defensive mission to secure the strait under a sustainable ceasefire

The UK and France hosted a further conference with 51 states on 17 April on the strait. Among the actions from the conference is that UK and France will establish a defensive multinational mission to maintain freedom of navigation in the strait, once a sustainable ceasefire is reached:

> France and the United Kingdom confirmed that they are establishing an independent and strictly defensive multinational mission to protect merchant vessels, reassure commercial shipping operators, and conduct mine clearance operations as soon as conditions permit following a sustainable ceasefire agreement.
>
> The international mission will be strictly defensive, and will operate in full accordance with international law and in consultation with relevant states. We are grateful to those nations that have indicated their readiness to contribute in compliance with their constitutional procedures, whether through military assets, logistical support, financial contributions or political solidarity, and call on all countries with an interest in the free flow of global trade to express their support for this initiative.
>
> The UK and France will jointly take forward this initiative, including coordinating military planning with contributing nations.[67]

The Prime Minister has also said a potential leaders-level summit may be held later in 2026.[68]

UK military commitments

In May, defence ministers from the UK, France and 40 other states held a meeting to discuss military commitments to a potential defensive mission to secure Hormuz after the conflict has ended.[69] This followed a military planning conference in late April.[70]

UK assets to be deployed include HMS Dragon and Typhoon jets

At the May conference, the UK Ministry of Defence said the UK deployment to the Gulf region would include:[71]

- Autonomous mine hunting equipment,
- The Royal Navy's modular 'Beehive' system. This can deliver autonomous "Kraken" drone boats.
- UK Typhoon jets (there is a pre-existing joint squadron in Qatar)
- British military mine-clearance specialists

67 HC Deb, 13 April 2026, c549; Prime Minister's Office, Re-opening the strait a global responsibility, 16 April 2026 and Joint statement by President Macron and Prime Minister Starmer, 17 April 2026
68 HC Deb, 13 April 2026, c568
69 Ministry of Defence, UK and France set to host multinational Strait of Hormuz meeting, 11 May 2026
70 Ministry of Defence, UK and France to lead multinational Strait of Hormuz military planning conference, 22 April 2026
71 Ministry of Defence, UK to contribute drones, jets and warship to multinational mission, 12 May 2026

- HMS Dragon. This Type 45 destroyer has a counter drone system

RFA Lyme Bay, an auxiliary dock landing ship, is being upgraded with uncrewed equipment, to allow it to act as a mobile command and launch vessel for autonomous systems (like drones). It has recently departed from Gibraltar for its potential role.[72] The deployments will be additional to personnel and equipment already deployed to the Middle East, as detailed in section 4.3 of the Commons Library briefing, Israel/US-Iran conflict 2026: Background and UK response.

HMS Middleton, a minesweeper, had been withdrawn from Bahrain for maintenance shortly before the conflict began in February.[73] US minesweeping capacity in the region is also limited.[74]

Iran has warned against any deployments

France has deployed an aircraft carrier group to the region in advance of a potential mission. HMS Dragon has joined it.[75]

Iran's foreign ministry has described the planned deployments as an "escalation of the crisis" and said it will "not allow any country to interfere" with the strait.[76]

The EU's mission in the Red Sea may also be expanded

There are reportedly discussions within NATO on supporting a Hormuz mission, but no plans have been confirmed.[77] The EU High Representative for Foreign Affairs, Kaja Kallas, has also said EU member states were discussing expanding their existing maritime operation in the Red Sea.[78] In June, the EU announced sanctions against two Iranian individuals and part of the IRGC Navy for their role in impeding freedom of navigation and instigating tolls.[79]

UK sanctions

In the UK Parliament, the Shadow Foreign Secretary, Dame Priti Patel, has called on the government to put additional pressure on Iran to reopen the strait through new sanctions, a "total ban on regime officials who might want to flee to the UK", and taking action on Iranian assets in the UK.[80]

The government says around £140 million of Iranian assets are frozen in the UK. In May, it announced sanctions on nine Iranian individuals and three

72 Ministry of Defence, UK to contribute drones, jets and warship to multinational mission, 12 May 2026; Royal Navy, RFA Lyme Bay departs Gibraltar, 25 May 2026
73 The Guardian, UK plans to send minesweeping drones to help reopen strait [...], 15 March 2026
74 Washington Post, America gave up some of its last minesweepers, 17 March 2026
75 France 24, French aircraft carrier pre-positions for possible Hormuz mission, 6 May 2026; Royal Navy, HMS Dragon supports French carrier strike group, 4 June 2026
76 BBC Monitoring, Iran warns UK, France over Hormuz warship deployment, 10 May 2026
77 Bloomberg, NATO is starting to consider Hormuz mission to protect ships, 19 May 2026
78 EU External Action, Press remarks by High Representative Kaja Kallas, 24 April 2026 and Informal meeting of Foreign Affairs Ministers (Gymnich), 28 May 2026
79 European Council, Freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz, 8 June 2026
80 HC Deb, 21 May 2026, c761

organisations to "deter attacks against dissidents overseas and disrupt illicit revenue generation for the Iranian regime".[81]

The UK applies a wide range of measures under its Iran sanctions regime. Section 6.2 of the Commons Library briefing Iran: Introductory country profile provides an overview.

1.5 April 2026: Russia and China veto a UN Security Council resolution

Bahrain's resolution had called on states to coordinate on defensive efforts

On 7 April, the UN Security Council voted on a draft resolution on Hormuz, presented by Bahrain and backed by several regional Arab states. The resolution called on states interested in the maritime corridor to "coordinate efforts" defensively and to contribute to ensuring the safety and security of navigation. This would include escorts for commercial ships.[82]

Bahrain had initially proposed a resolution endorsing "all necessary means" to secure the strait, but this language was not in the final draft.[83]

China and Russia vetoed the resolution. Russia described the resolution as "unbalanced, inaccurate, and confrontational", saying that the root causes of the conflict lay with Israel and the US, some of the strait was in Iranian territorial waters, and it was opposed to potential sanctions. China echoed these statements, criticising the "one-sided condemnation and pressure" on Iran and said that the council "must not provide the legal veneer for unauthorized military operations". Both said they would propose an alternative resolution to the council. This has not been published.[84]

Separately, China has called on Iran to guarantee freedom of navigation in the strait as the "shared call of the international community".[85]

The UK Government expressed disappointment at the Russian and Chinese vetoes and said it would continue its own diplomatic initiatives to reopen the strait (see above). It said that Russia and China had "chose[n] to shield their ally, Iran".[86] The US also criticised the vetoes.[87]

81 HC Deb, 21 May 2026, c762; FCDO, UK sanctions Iranian targets, 11 May 2026
82 UN Security Council, Draft resolution S/2026/273 and S/PV.10130, 11 April 2026
83 Reuters, Bahrain pushes UN-backed action for Hormuz shipping, 23 March 2026; Security Council report (not affiliated with the UN), Vote on a draft resolution on the Strait of Hormuz, 6 April 2026
84 Russian Representative to the UN, Explanation of vote by permanent representative, 7 April 2026; Chinese Representative to the UN, Explanation of Vote by Ambassador Fu Cong, 7 April 2026
85 BBC Monitoring, China asks Iran to guarantee freedom of navigation in Strait, 16 April 2026
86 Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO), It is deeply regrettable that this resolution did not pass, 7 April 2026
87 US Mission to the UN, Explanation of vote on a UN Security Council resolution, 7 April 2026

Further draft resolutions are under discussion

The two resolutions drafted by the US and France have not been published

In May, both the US and France said they were preparing new resolutions on the strait. Neither resolution has been published and no date has been set for a vote.

On 5 May, the US Mission to the UN said their draft resolution is a "narrower" resolution than that rejected by the UN Security Council in April.[88]

Bahrain, which has supported the US in drafting the resolution, says that it "calls for Iran to immediately cease all attacks" in the strait and addresses the placement of mines and "illegal tolling".[89] The US says it also includes a requirement for Iran to publish the number and location of the sea mines and establish a humanitarian corridor for shipping. The text has the support of Kuwait, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the UAE.[90]

On 22 May, France said it was preparing an alternative resolution. The Foreign Ministry said that it has "prepared [...] a draft resolution that could be discussed if the conditions are right" for an international mission to restore freedom of navigation.[91] See above, section 1.4, for UK-French efforts on a defensive mission to secure the strait.

1.6 Further reading

Legal commentary

- Just Security, Five "blockades" and one legal problem, 1 May 2026
- Reuters, Can Iran legally impose tolls on the Strait of Hormuz?, 16 April 2026
- Chatham House, The Strait of Hormuz, shipping, and law, 13 April 2026
- Just Security, Iran's unlawful mining and the US port blockade, 13 April 2026
- The Conversation, Strait of Hormuz: Why the US and Iran are sailing in very different legal waters, 15 April 2026
- The Conversation, Would a US blockade of the Strait of Hormuz be legal?, 13 April 2026

88 Reuters, US, Gulf Arab nations draft new UN resolution, 4 May 2026; US Mission to the UN, The US proposes a UN Security Council resolution [...], 5 May 2026

89 UN, Bahrain and US float security council resolution on the Strait of Hormuz, 7 May 2026

90 As above US Mission to the UN, The US proposes a UN Security Council resolution [...], 5 May 2026

91 Reuters, France readies UN resolution on Hormuz as vote on US text stalls, 22 May 2026

- Just Security, Strait of Hormuz: Why Iran's hold is illegal and US military force alone fails, 8 April 2026
- Just Security, Legal and operational issues in the Strait of Hormuz, 15 March 2026

Other issues

- UN Conference on Trade and Development, Strait of Hormuz Disruptions: The burden of oil price shocks on vulnerable economies, 2 June 2026
- Crisis Group, The state of the strait: The role of Hormuz in the Middle East war so far, 26 May 2026
- Royal United Services Institute, The US blockade of Hormuz: Who holds the advantage?, 5 May 2026
- Chatham House, A naval coalition in the Strait of Hormuz should learn these lessons, 1 May 2026
- International Institute for Strategic Studies, Choppy waters in the Strait of Hormuz, 19 March 2026
- Crisis Group, With a fragile ceasefire under threat, what future for the Strait of Hormuz?, 10 April 2026
- Foreign Policy, Europe is looking for its own Hormuz fix, 14 April 2026
- Chatham House, How to keep the Strait of Hormuz open in the long term, 10 April 2026

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